The Society

By J. Omar Hansen

BYRON: Well.

KEATS: Yes, well. I agree.

BYRON: It has been a long time.

KEATS: It has. A year to be exact.

BYRON: I am overwhelmed.

KEATS: We must begin.

BYRON: Of course, you are right. *(The two men take their seats at the ends of the table.)*

INTRODUCTION

BYRON: Art is a tool used to convey meaning.
KEATS: or at least, that's what the majority of people believe.
BYRON: In fact, art is the absence of meaning.
KEATS: That's what gives it resonance.
BYRON: The one true way to ruin art is to force a meaning on it.
KEATS: And this atrocity would never occur in:
BOTH: "The Society"
KEATS: By J. Omar Hansen

BYRON: (*BYRON stands.)* Let it be known that the society of Poets of the World and the Universe comes now to a poetic order.

KEATS: Nice touch.

BYRON: Thank you. We shall be favored to hear the minutes read. *(B YRON sits down and KEA TS rises with a sheet of line paper.)*

KEATS: I will now read the minutes of the last meeting. Minutes read. Opening

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

remarks. Poetry read. Lively discussion. No. bloodshed. Dues collected. Closing remarks. *(KEATS sits.)*

BYRON: Thank you. We will now have the opening remarks. Gentlemen, the state of the arts is at an all-time low. The theatre is dead. Has been for years. The painterly arts are in flux. Music remains melodic and therefore dubious and inconsequential. Film never really was an art form. The novel is fare for the masses, and the short story gets longer every year. It is poetry, and poetry alone, that remains a viable art. And why, you will ask? Simply put: we have escaped the foul dredge of meaning. The putrid cesspool of reason. We are art and art is us. We are poetry and therein a light in and of ourselves. *(KEATS starts to applaud. BYRON stares at KEATS with irritation. KEATS stops.)* We bind ourselves to no outside order. Order is chaos. Chaos is order. Here, in this place, and this place alone, may the muses reside and flourish. *(BYRON sits down. KEATS applauds loudly.)*

KEATS: Dear me.

BYRON: Thank you.

KEATS: That was beautiful.

BYRON: You are too kind.

KEATS: I think I must weep.

BYRON: Don't.

KEATS: Poetic.

BYRON: Yes.

KEATS: The report from the secretary?

BYRON: Funding has stopped. The government refuses aid.

KEATS: Death to all tyrants, the presidency to all morons!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BYRON: Calm yourself.

KEATS: You are right ... I move we proceed with the reading of new works commissioned after last year's conference.

BYRON: I second. Who shall begin?

KEATS: May I?

BYRON: By all means.

KEATS: *(KEATS stands. A pause)* "Trample" ... Horse's hoof... on my... flat face. *(He sits. BYRON sits staring in awe.)*

BYRON: What brevity ... I could see it... The horse... the hoof...the face. It is a masterpiece. It is utterly meaningless.

KEATS: You are too kind.

BYRON: May I?

KEATS: Oh yes, please. We are off to such a good start.

BYRON: *(He stands and puts on reading glasses.)* "Going to the park, and being very cold on a winter's night in Manhattan, when I thought I loved, but it was nothing."

KEATS: That's the title?

BYRON: *(Taken aback)* Yes.

KEATS: Oh, but I like it. I do. Very poetic.

BYRON: Oh. Do you think so?

KEATS: Oh, yes. Absolutely.

BYRON: ... Ashen black frostbite... toes ... purple pain... *(A small envelope is pushed under the door. KEATS sees it.)* ... you, black-brown lipped...

KEATS: Did you see that?

BYRON: What?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

KEATS: There by the door.

BYRON: I'm not done.

KEATS: Someone pushed an envelope under the door.

BYRON: But I'm not done.

KEATS: Someone has pushed ...

BYRON: It's not fair.

KEATS: I...

BYRON: You got to read yours.

KEATS: But someone has pushed an envelope under the door. *(This registers to BYRON for the first time. He gasps.)* Should we see what it is?

BYRON: You mean it came from the other side of the door?

KEATS: Yes. I don't know what it could mean.

BYRON: *(Frightened)* Well, perhaps one of us should see what it is.

KEATS: Yes, I agree.

BYRON: *(He doesn't want to.)* Do you want me to?

KEATS: Well, I'll do it.

BYRON: All right. *(KEATS walks over to the door and picks up the envelope. He looks at the door with a worried glance and then back at BYRON.)*

KEATS: Perhaps we should call out to see who put it under the ...

BYRON: No! No, don't! It could be the ruin of the society! *(KEATS jumps away from the door.)* What is it?

KEATS: *(He opens the envelope.)* Why... it's a poem. It's a poem. Do you want me to read it?

BYRON: No, no, it's from the outside. I think we ought to put it back where it ...

KEATS: It's rather interesting.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BYRON: You didn't read it did you?

KEATS: I did. I want to read it to the society.

BYRON: I am against it.

KEATS: We must be bold.

BYRON: Very well. It's on your head. *(BYRON goes to his seat and sits. KEATS walks to his seat and stands and then reads.)*

KEATS: So much depends ... on what I write ... and what they think ... But never the twain shall meet. *(A long pause)*

BYRON: It smacks of meaning!

KEATS: What?

BYRON: I'll say it again! It smacks of meaning.

KEATS: I think you're right. What do we do?

BYRON: Put it back.

KEATS: Under the door?

BYRON: Yes, yes!

KEATS: Now?

BYRON: The sooner the better. *(KEATS walks over to the door and kneels down and almost pushes it under. He stops.)*

KEATS: Why do you think they pushed it to us?

BYRON: To corrupt us. They want to corrupt us! Push it back!

KEATS: But... the door... this has never happened before. There's someone out there.

BYRON: Corruption.

KEATS: Really?

BYRON: If you won't push it back at least leave it on the floor and read some

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

more poetry. Come ... read.

KEATS: Perhaps you're right.

BYRON: Read another of your poems.

KEATS: But yours wasn't finished.

BYRON: That's all right. Read. *(KEATS looks at the table for a minute and then stands with another poem. He looks at the envelope by the door)* Don't look at it! *(KEATS looks away. He looks again at his poem.)*

KEATS: "The Night" ... Cool blackness ... More or less ... It is a...

BYRON: That rhymed!

KEATS: No it didn't.

BYRON: Yes it did. You read a rhyme.

KEATS: No I didn't!

BYRON: I know a read rhyme when it rends my ear. That was a rhyme.

KEATS: Well... perhaps. Sometimes I like rhyme.

BYRON: What?

KEATS: I like rhymes!

BYRON: I don't believe it. The corruption has started. That envelope! It will be the ruin of us all. I must destroy it! *(BYRON lunges towards the envelope but KEATS overtakes him and physically keeps him from the envelope.)* Let me destroy it, I tell you!

KEATS: Stop it! Stop it! You're being absurd!

BYRON: Thank you.

KEATS: I didn't mean it as a compliment.

BYRON: How else should I take it?

KEATS: I'm going out the door.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BYRON: *(BYRON gasps in horror)* No!

KEATS: I think I must.

BYRON: You don't understand. You are young. There is corruption out there. There is meaning out there!

KEATS: How do you know?

BYRON: I can't tell you!

KEATS: *(He goes to BYRON and confronts him.)* I want to know!

BYRON: *(Sobbing, he falls to his knees.)* I can't! Don't make me. Please don't make me!

KEATS: *(He grabs BYRON by the lapel.) Tell me!*

BYRON: *(Slowly)...* I know... because I went through the door! But I was lucky. I saw the corruption. I saw meaning and knew it would destroy me. How I found the room again, I don't know. But you mustn't try it. You won't return. Others have gone. The society remains here. But they don't return. Please, listen to me.

KEATS: But what did it mean? Never the twain shall meet?

BYRON: Don't you see what's happening to you? You asked what it meant. Do you hear what you said?

KEATS: Did I say that?

BYRON: You did. *(KEATS walks over to the door and picks up the envelope.)* Don't do it! Don't do it! ... Push it back under. Come away from the door. *(For a long pause KEATS stands with the envelope in his hand. Finally he pushes it back under the door. He walks slowly back to BYRON who embraces him.)* Dear boy, you have won. The battle is won... I think we should continue ... But no more poems. After this they might be perceived as purposeful.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Come, let's return and finish the conference. There still is left the collection of dues. *(They both go back to the table. BYRON takes a plate that was sitting on the table, blows off the dust and pushes it over to KEATS' side of the table. KEATS looks at it with a worried look. He feels in his pocket. He pushes the plate over to BYRON's side of the table. BYRON turns and sees it. He looks a little embarrassed.)* ... Now for the final remarks ... Once again we are reaffirmed. We are the last bastion of artistry. We live to be as art.

KEATS: That's very beautiful.

BYRON: Thank you. We are adjourned. Come embrace me. It has been a marvelous experience.

KEATS: Yes.

BYRON: Till next year?

KEATS: Next year. *(BYRON smiles and then goes to a corner of the room farthest from the door. He lays down and sleeps. KEATS watches him and then looks at the door. He walks over to BYRON and sees that he is asleep. He looks at the door and then at BYRON. He walks to the door. He tries the knob and it opens. He looks back at BYRON. He exits out the door. BYRON begins to snore quietly as the lights fade to black.)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: J. Omar Hansen
Book: Play it Again!
ISBN: 978-0916260972
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 1993